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Ellen Rowe

Ellen Rowe has made her mark in the jazz world as a pianist, composer, and as a celebrated jazz educator at the University of Michigan. She is on the board of the International Society of Jazz Arrangers and Composers, and serves as the coordinator for the Jazz Education Network Sisters in Jazz Competition.

Ellen was interviewed via Zoom on December 2, 2024 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have Ellen Rowe with me today, and you're in Michigan, correct?

ER: Um hum. University yeah, of Michigan.

MR: I've seen your name for years and when I first saw it I wondered if I had a long lost relative.

ER: Same here. Same here. I was going back through the family tree but I'm not sure you're on it.

MR: I think it was Fats Waller who said, "one never knows, do one?"

ER: Exactly. Exactly.

MR: Well congratulations on your career, I'm going to use the term "illustrious."

ER: Well thank you.

MR: Yeah.

ER: I appreciate that.

MR: I'd like to start out with a question that's been on my mind. If you think back to when you were at the University of Connecticut, earlier in your career, and you think of what you might have advised to jazz students back then and if you compare it with what you may do now, what are the significant differences?

ER: That is an excellent question. Yeah, I think about that a good bit. I mean especially my faculty colleagues and I, if they're over the age of 50 we find ourselves definitely questioning some things that we took for granted when we were first starting out to teach. And I'd say one of the big ones is that I think when I started at U Conn there's still pretty much a tried and true way for young students to, you know, get their feet wet and go to the jam sessions that existed at the time, to point them towards working bands that still existed, and you know maybe even with the more famous ones saying look you know you're not ready for this right now but these bands are out there and if you go to all these — you know if there's somebody you want to play with and you go to all their gigs and you know just pester — not pester them in a bad way but you know let them know who you are and work on all their music and you know that used to be a big part of our spiel,

and I mean it still is in the sense that if somebody is in love with, you know, Brian Blade's music and you know we're certainly going to say hey go to all his gigs and try and get to know him and his players. But I think we are aware that students are learning, they are finding different paths and there's so much entrepreneurship involved now because there's so many different ways that students can get their music out there, can connect with other students, you know ways of creating their music that's very different from before with, you know, all the DOSS and layering and you know the ease that they have with all kinds of technology. So I think what most of us have found is that we are trying to advise students down a lot of different paths. Like just you know saying there's a lot of different avenues open to you now and still maintain every ounce of integrity, you know, that we can encourage them to have to be the very best players and composers they can be, to study the masters, but to just realize that there's going to be different vehicles for them to get their music out there and to meet people and you know and of course there's a lot more happening on line and things like that. That's I'd say — and then also just that, you know even tunes that get played at jam sessions have evolved. I don't mean evolved, I guess I should say changed. I don't want to say the tunes they're playing now are better or worse, but you know so there's a different kind of, an expanding body of standard repertoire, let's put it that way, that people need to know. So those are a few things. I'm sure I'll think of some more but that's part of it.

MR: Could I zone in on a word you used, "integrity." What did you mean by that? I was interested to learn when I interviewed Randy Brecker that much of what he does now is he stays at home and people send him tracks and he plays various solos on them.

ER: Yeah.

MR: I'm not saying that has something to do with integrity but it is an eye opener.

ER: Um hum. Yeah. It's definitely a shift. I've been hearing that more and more from players, that that's a big part of what they do now. And yeah, I mean I think in order to be one of those players that's going to have those tracks sent to them, like a Randy Brecker or Marshall Gilkes or whoever it might be, you have to be at the very top of your game still. So I mean I think when I was using the word "integrity" I was thinking about the fact that there's not as many gatekeepers out there in terms of putting your music out. I mean there's a lot of very — I'll just try to be kind and say marginal — you know things that younger players are now able to put out and it's not because they're not talented it's just because they're you know young, and they can just thrown anything out on the web that they want to and you know I think all of us are trying to encourage our younger players to, you know, make sure that they're getting their material vetted by older players and teachers and people that have an interest in their careers, and just to make sure it's of the highest quality possible, since it is so easy to record something in your bedroom, you

know layer it up and send it out and there it goes and you know nobody over the age of 18 has heard it before, it's just heading out there. You know so I think that's what I meant, just to make sure that even though there might be avenues — a lot more avenues open to putting your music out there, to make sure you're being very critical of yourself and you know, attending to the best practices for learning to play, learning to compose.

MR: As a teacher, do you find that you need to try and guide students through their choices on an endless smorgasbord of things that they can listen to? I guess what I'm after is I remember years ago when this whole thing — everything is available — was just starting and suggesting a Cannonball tune to one of my students and it was sort of like, "Oh yes I've heard that on YouTube, I heard it on YouTube." And I just got — the way he said it seemed to be like, "Yeah and I've heard everything else that you're about to suggest too." And how well have you heard it? Or you just heard it once? I don't have a question here, more like an observation.

ER: It's a well founded observation, yeah. We talk to our students about — do you just have — you know your headphones are on almost continually but are you multi-tasking? What else are you doing when you're (I'm using air quotes here) "listening" to the music? You know and do you have it on at your house while you're doing ten million other things? So yeah, we talk a lot about the need to do deep listening. And that's why we're still forcing transcriptions and things like that. You know I give assignments where I ask people to try to check out a bass line or, you know, non-bassists. And things like that, just to really remind them what deep listening is. And the other problem, and I know I'm preaching to the choir here, is that YouTube and Spotify, you know they're all there and you can certainly hear lots of music, but you know there used to be liner notes and there used to be things that told you who else was on the cut. And you know somebody'll say, "Oh yeah, I've heard this tune." I'll say, "Oh, do you remember which recording of it you head?" No they don't. "Do you remember who was playing?" And no, they don't know that. So you know I don't mean to sound like an old fogey here but something is lost in the way that music is being consumed right now I think. And it's an educator's job as far as I'm concerned to get that information, make sure they have that information because it's important.

MR: It's very interesting how, you mentioned deep listening and how connected it is to technology. Because I was reading your bio and it reminded me of how I used to learn songs from records. So you know I want to learn the bass line first and there was this constant putting the needle down, getting a couple of measures, picking the needle up. I mean that was deep. Because you had no choice, it was deep.

ER: Exactly. Yeah. I remember like cassette recordings I had of Marian McPartland when I was trying to transcribe her solo piano albums and you know it was push and rewind and

push and rewind and push and rewind. And you know the other beauty about that was that — one tape I remember in particular was running almost a half-step sharp and I transcribed a solo piece for — it was, she used to do these portraits of her guests sometimes on the Piano Jazz show. And she did a portrait of Dudley Moore. And I painstakingly took that sucker down. I could not believe she had played in C sharp minor but you know she was Marian, she could play in any key. And sure enough she goes, "I could never play this" or whatever it was, and yeah, she had played it in C minor. But that was a lesson to myself to somehow find a way to check those. But yeah, and I got off track here because I had something else I was planning to say. Oh yeah, the drop the needle — yeah I mean I almost kind of say that, and especially in my jazz pedagogy classes I say that jazz pedagogy is a double edged sword because we have all these technical wonders at our disposal, we have all the streaming sites which of course I have very mixed feelings about as do any other composers and performers who are not getting any royalties. But there's how-to books and how-to videos and there's all types of pre-transcribed solos out there that people can use, and etude books. And you know I mean I think they're all out there, being put out there by very well meaning people but the you know I think we both agree that the way you really get at the essence of what's going on is to do this deep listening and to teach yourself, you know do the transcribing yourself, not play somebody's transcription that's already out there. So I mean I think we need to honor the roots of the music by doing as much work by ear as we can and take advantage of the pedagogical benefits I guess, if that's the right word, of having all this material at our disposal. But you know I think about the way all the great masters learned. You know they didn't have Aebersold play-a-longs and etude books and pre-transcribed solos and things like that. And I would argue that their method of learning created the masters that they are. So yeah. I could go on and on about this but —

MR: Who are the great masters for 20-year-olds now? I mean we moved from generation to generation. You know Coltrane was the zenith for many years. Who do they cite now as their influences?

ER: You know I mean it's very interesting and that's another great question. I mean we do ask a lot of the young students coming in to audition for us who apply to Michigan, you know who are you checking out and who are you interested in and you know almost to a fault there'll be Coltrane or Parker or Sonny Rollins are still on the list. I mean I think that those players are still incredibly important to them. But there will be you know Patrick Bartley and you know, other younger players, and sometimes there are players that you know we haven't heard of because you know they're not huge names but they are occupying a corner of the young player universe that we just haven't accessed yet. But it's an interesting mix of still the masters, which is great, or the people we think of as

the masters. But also a body of younger players. And you know I don't notice players so much — like Michael Brecker's name may come up but it seems like there's maybe a generation of players that are not getting listened to as much and maybe so we sort of stop in the early '60s and then they sort of missed some of the '60s, '70s and '80s, and then it's more into the 2000s. So this is the first time I'm really thinking about it this way so it's a half-formed thought but it does seem like the early masters are there and then maybe there's the Joe Hendersons or the, you know, the players who are a little bit younger and maybe not getting the attention that we might hope. And then there's a bunch of younger players.

MR: I'd like to talk about your composing and you introduced the word "deep," so I'm going to go deep.

ER: Okay.

MR: It has to do with music and meaning and intent. That your albums seem to have an intent, sometimes more obvious than others. And I was listening and reading about your "Portraits of Women in Motion." I have a little quote — this was a review, I think you're probably familiar with it. And the reviewer said, "For one thing Rowe's writing is trying to tell a story and if you don't know that 'Game, Set and Match' is a tribute to Billie Jean King and Martina Navratilova then the bouncing two note horn shots at the beginning of the piece don't make as much sense as when you imagine them as the sound of a volley at the French Open."

ER: Yeah. So I will say that is one of the most overt attempts that I've ever made in any kind of music so yeah it was one of those things where I was really struggling to think how — because I don't normally do this. I thought you know wouldn't it be fun to see if I could. I played tennis all through high school and tried to play in college until I realized that Eastman School of Music did not have a tennis team and they did not want me running over to the University of Rochester. So you know I knew a lot about it and I knew how it sounded when the ball hit and the volleys and this and that. So that was definitely very much, you know, text painting — well there's no text but you know you get the idea. And like I said I don't normally do that but in that case it was a fun challenge and you know I think it was maybe a little silly but it worked out and it was a nice theme and it kind of I think branched out that way. But I don't normally try to do that. Things are a little bit more — are less obvious.

MR: Less dramatic perhaps. But so you're going to write about Michelle Obama, do you have a process that before you even touch a keyboard or however you — do you think about the subject first and maybe come up with adjectives or themes to guide you?

ER: Yeah. I think, in that piece I was just thinking about the aspects of her that I most admired and you know I don't know that I'm consciously trying to go, you know, trying

to turn them into themes or things like that. But there was a definite — I think maybe the most telling thing is that you know it's a waltz but on the top of the music for the players it says "Funky Yet Graceful." And so I was trying to find something that had some blues elements in it, with chords that moved in slightly unusual ways for a jazz waltz. But also a certain grace in terms of things not being too herky jerky but things moving smoothly. So I mean I think that was kind of the approach on it was that I wanted to be somewhat sophisticated, as she clearly is, but also that you know soul and funk that she's also known for. So that was kind of the thinking in putting that one together.

MR: Steve Allen — I was lucky to interview Steve Allen years ago. And I asked him about song titles. Like do they usually have a meaning. And Steve Allen had strong opinions. And he said, "I should say that there's really no meaning, nor could there be any meaning to a pure melody. So then he went on to say a melody could have a mood but I always remember that because sometimes song titles are hard. I'm going to ask a question that's going to sound almost like it could be an insult but it's not.

ER: Okay.

MR: Have you ever written anything that's basically meaningless?

ER: Oh yeah. I mean I think I've had a couple what you might call throw-aways that, you know, I don't write a lot of medium tempo swingers or whatever it might be, I'm just going to write something and then you know you come up with it and then maybe it doesn't feel like it was, you know, a lot of soul searching went into it and there's not a lot of passion or deep personal connection but at the end of the day it's a serviceable tune, you can take it in and play it on a trio gig and at that point yeah, the title becomes — oh well here's a good example. And I actually like this tune, I like the way it came out, but I thought, I just recorded what's hopefully going to be a new quartet album over the — well actually no, about six weeks ago. And I wanted something that was maybe a little bit more Blakey-Messenger, just something, because there was a lot of original things in the album and I wanted — it just allowed us to swing and have fun. And so that one, I wrote it and like I said I think it turned out reasonably well, but I wrote it quickly. And at the end of the day the title became "Hot Off the Press" because that's what it was. I had written it the night before the session and brought it in. So you know somewhat meaningless but it turned out okay.

MR: What did you say the title was?

ER: "Hot Off the Press." Not the most original.

MR: That's okay. I mean how many times have people been like right in the studio and they make up a blues because they've got four minutes left on the record and they have to come up — you know sometimes the producer does it.

ER: Yeah. No it's — I don't do it a lot but yeah every so often I do and it's fun to see that you don't necessarily have to put in days of angst and labor to come up with a nice tune that people like to play, so —

MR: Have you transitioned from — I have a little prop here. This is a Thad Jones arrangement, a small group arrangement for Joe Williams.

ER: Oh, nice.

MR: It's the real thing. And I wondered if you've transitioned from the pencil and score to Finale or whatever?

ER: Oh boy you're asking such great questions. Yeah I have a million pencil scores lying around here I could hold up as my prop. Yeah I'm something of a — I don't want to say — I'm not a troglodyte, maybe a Luddite is a better word. I grew up of a similar generation to Mike Holober and Maria Schneider and you know various people who still need to have the pencil on the paper. And you know the various modes now where people like obviously Maria and you know Mike, they can get their music copied if it's a project for the WADR or whatever, they have that at their disposal. And you know I know Mike at least is conversant with Sibelius or Finale, whichever program he uses or used to use. But I have just been lucky enough — well maybe stupid enough I'm not sure what the right word is, to be at a university, you can get some grants to get copying done. When I get commissions I ask to have some of the copying costs folded in if I can. But the thing is that it's so important to me to be putting the notes on the page myself. You know I studied with Ray Wright at Eastman and he taught us all the importance of the clean score, which at the time was pencil and paper and then pen and ink parts, which are a nightmare that I'm happy to at least not be doing that anymore. But the reality is I need to learn, you know I'm going to retire in a couple of years and I'll need to be doing my own copying and you know it's interesting now because there's a big conversation going on because now Finale is out — is gone. People are talking about well should I switch to Sibelius or Dorico and which is the best. And so I think probably what I'll end up doing is learning Dorico hopefully over the summer, and just having to — you know I'll still do the pencil scores but I'll just have to enter them in myself and you know, learn to create parts. Probably should have gotten a head start on this.

MR: It's a deep dive and the thing about Finale that I've discovered is that it's hard to stop fussing with it.

ER: Ah. Okay.

MR: If you can just keep moving things around and come back to it and like it never ends. You know Dave Rivello said — I went to his house and there's his big score pads and everything and he was saying I think the act of putting a pencil and writing a note is important.

ER: Um hum. I do too.

MR: Then he would Finale it afterwards.

ER: Yeah, this again is another subject I'm passionate about and I'll talk for hours — I'll promise not to but I could. Yeah. I find, I can tell a difference between a student who has entered some big band score just on their computer, and a student who has taken the time to really sit down and try voicings and things out at the piano and done it by hand. Yeah it's so important for me to think about the players who are playing the parts as I'm you know putting them out, and I'm really trying to think linearly — I'm not pronouncing that well but you know what I mean, as opposed, no, in addition to vertically. And I think that's actually the nicest compliments I've ever gotten are from players who say hey I really enjoyed playing your music, you know because the parts were fun to play is generally what they're getting at. So I think that a lot of that comes from the pencil and the paper. And I just feel more ownership, I feel closer to it and you know of course Dave studied with Rayburn Wright as well so we're all cut from the same cloth.

MR: Have you ever written a chart that did not have any improvised solos in it?

ER: I haven't, and I've thought a lot about Brookmeyer and Bill Holman says this too sometimes in that — I can't remember which one of them it was who was saying this but hey this is my music, I want control over it, I don't think there is the need constantly to always have improvised solos. But you know I'm generally writing for bands where it's expected to have improvised solos and there's great soloists, or I'm writing secondary school music and you want the students improvising. It's critical, you know, part of their — so I haven't really been in a situation — maybe I wrote one piece where there is this very short amount of improvisation but in general I haven't done that.

MR: It's tricky because I've tried it one or two times and what you find is you're writing and writing and writing and then you come up — so far I've got 90 seconds of music. You know we rely on improvised solos to at least give some length to the piece.

ER: We do, yeah. And frankly it's a moment where I know the rhythm section is just like oh thank God, I can just comp, I can just walk, I can whatever. And I know my band, my University of Michigan band, that's a moment where they kind of come together and they look at the soloists and they're really enjoying what the soloist is doing. And it's a feel good moment, so obviously there's a lot of benefits to it, but yeah. It would be hard to do that.

MR: By the way I watched a video of you conducting one of the university bands and I noticed two alto flutes and a bass flute. And I said wow — what a luxury.

ER: Oh. I know what you saw. Yeah.

MR: Was that the Gil Evans —

ER: Exactly. I think yeah, because there's not a lot of complete videos, well maybe there's some livestreams out there but yeah, that's very rare and I think if you look closely you saw that one of the members of the sax section was considerably older than the others and that was my colleague Andrew Bishop sitting in on alto flute. Yeah. Alto flute is not a double that many of our students — I think we own one in the department but yeah.

MR: Were you one of the few women in the Eastman program at the time?

ER: Yes. I was, yeah. I think about this a lot. There's a wonderful younger writer who, you know none of us could have an undergraduate jazz major at the time because there wasn't one. There was a master's degree which is why I stayed on. But a wonderful composer/arranger Shari Feder who is there. She went more the jingles and commercial music route. She was a couple of years behind me. And of course Maria came in a year after me. And there were some really good, you know, players there. I know I'm going to be forgetting people. Diane White was a wonderful jazz trumpet player. But again, the undergrads had to be classical majors who happened to also be good jazz players. And we didn't have that many women coming in at the masters level except, you know, like Maria and occasionally some others as well. But yeah, I was definitely one of a few women there.

MR: How do you feel about the state of women in jazz right now? I'm going to read a quote from Karolina Strassmayer. She was talking about the expectations of a woman and "How can I embody the spirit of jazz if I'm concerned whether people like me or they think that I'm pretty or they think that I'm nice. So I found that there's a contradiction between my socialization as a girl, as a woman, and the music I play."

ER: Well of course needless to say I think about this constantly, you know especially with trying to get a lot of young women in our program which we've been, I'll say I've been pretty good at. I think we have nine or ten women in our program of 55 students, and that's without a jazz vocal program, so these are all instrumentalists. Yeah I think that's an ongoing concern for younger women. I think it's less of a concern than it was 30, 40 years ago. I see a lot of my younger women students are just really gung-ho and I'm going to be who I'm going to be and if the guys don't like it that's too bad and you know, things like that, which I think is great. Because the guys don't have to worry about that. I think the situation for women in jazz is getting better and better by the day. I mean we still have plenty of issues, you know just around looking after ourselves and you know safely and you know there's still, well I don't need to go into it but there's still issues of women not being treated as respectfully as they should be in many different types of ways. But I see a lot more young women playing, getting the encouragement to play. We had the most applicants for the Sisters in Jazz Collegiate Combo Competition which I oversee for the Jazz Education Network this year that we had — I think we had over 50,

which is great. And that's a really positive, positive sign. So I think things are improving. I think a lot more is being written about it. There's more awareness, and I counsel my young women to be strong and stick up for themselves and play the music they want to play, express themselves the way they want to play. But yeah, it's still hard. I mean it's not quite a level playing field.

MR: Have you ever had to have a discussion with skeptical parents about actually their son or daughter going into this field?

ER: Sure. Yes. Absolutely. And Michigan being a Research 1 institution and obviously an excellent institution for many different types of things, is a place that students often will come and double major, sometimes because they really have a passionate interest in both jazz and something else, and partly because maybe their parents want them to have the — well it's hard to know which is the back-up degree sometimes, but they want them to have that other degree so that they will be ensured of getting a job when they get out. So when we have those conversations we talk about the myriad ways that students can earn a living in music, and the fact that we have a great diversity of musical offerings for them to follow, paths to follow once they come to school and then we have things like our Entrepreneurship and Leadership Program which is going to help give them business skills. You know between composing, arranging, videogame music, teaching privately, teaching academically in a high school or college, performing — there's just so many avenues. And then some of them get — end up doing a lot of class work in our Performing Arts Technology degree which is helping them learn all the technology and getting their chops to work in a studio, things like that. So yeah I have those conversations but I think Michigan is pretty well equipped to give students a well-rounded program so they can go out and work.

MR: If you had a nephew or a niece that was oh let's say 15 and their aspirations were to become a musician, do you have any advice at that point in their lives? I bring it up because I've lost track of how many people have said, "Don't go into jazz unless you don't have any other choice." Even Phil Woods. He said, "If you're debating about being a brain surgeon or a tenor man, go with the brain surgery."

ER: Yeah, I mean definitely. You've got to be passionate about it. You know this is not the complete flip side but I've also been around John Clayton when he has talked about students saying that they're going to go into — you know they're going to do jazz but they're going to do music education as a fallback. And he's saying okay, you're a parent, do you want your child being taught by somebody for whom education, you know teaching is just a fallback? Something they didn't really want to do. And so you know he's really strong on if you're going to teach you need to want to teach and really love it and be passionate about it. And you know I feel the same way about playing jazz. I mean

if you've got the drive and the burning desire I think you can do it. And of course talent helps and I would encourage you to do it. But not if you don't have that. If it's just kind of a hobby for you then that's great, it can always be a hobby. Go to a school where you can continue to play but yeah, don't go after it as a career unless there's nothing else that you want to do and that's it, you're really sold on it.

MR: Did you have that decision to make early on about oh I'm going to try to make a living just as a performer or no I like to teach so I'll do both?

ER: So my dad was a high school band director and there was lots of instruments laying around our house. I inherited perfect pitch from him and you know I thought I was being bad when parents were over the house and I was putting together all the instruments trying to figure out how to play them. You know I thought I was some kind of criminal. But so music came naturally to me as a child, which was great, I mean what a blessing. And then I kind of got into high school and I was just playing all the time, flute and piano, and taught myself bassoon because there was no bassoon players in the high school. But I think I kind of — my band director took me aside, because I was also an athlete and playing lots of sports. And he said, "You know you're really going to have to make a choice right now, I mean if you're going to continue on in music you need to start thinking seriously about auditions and going to music school and if sports are going to continue to occupy as much of your time as they are that's going to be difficult." So I didn't give up sports but I kind of got my priorities realigned. And so I think at the time I assumed that I would just continue being a musician and see where it brought me, and music education was my best avenue to get into a school because I wasn't a — you know my parents had never forced lessons on me except for the jazz lessons that I forced on myself at age — or my band director forced on me — at age 14 when he said, "If you're going to play in my high school jazz band you are going to actually learn something about jazz." And so off I went and then I just — wow, this is so exciting and cool. So this is a very long answer to your question, I apologize, but what I'm getting at is by the time I got to Eastman and started discovering jazz and realized that writing was something I apparently was reasonably good at and got to continue studying with Ray Wright I did finish up my music education degree and I did go out and do my student teaching. But then I moved to New York because I wanted to see what that was about. And I actually fell into my first college teaching job. It was really by accident. I was at the time thinking I was probably going to continue to just try to freelance and see where that took me. But I was working on the S.S. Norway on a cruise ship and I got a — I don't know if it was a telegram at that time or what it was on board the ship — from Ray Wright saying that the University of Connecticut, where I grew up, was going to try to start a jazz program and they had an opening for a half time person and was I interested. He had recommended

me. And yeah, one thing led to another and I ended up getting that job. And like I said, I kind of fell into it and it's always been interesting to me because I had a therapist once who talked about the fact that many women, maybe not so much now but at least when I was growing up — were, as she put it, "contingency oriented." We go from contingency to contingency dealing with each thing as it comes along instead of going, "I want to be Joni Mitchell's musical director" or whatever that might be. And so I kind of look at it that way. I think I'm lucky that I had the tools to be able to step into that job and realize that it was really rewarding and challenging and fun and then one thing led to another and I got out to Michigan. But I think had I really been able to ask myself what I most wanted, you know say in college I might have been allowed to think this way, and I don't know why I wasn't but you know I might have said I would love to play piano for an artist I admire, like a Joni Mitchell. But I had no concept that that was possible or that such a thing was possible, and so I was just kind of going along doing what I was told to do and trying to do it as well as I could. And I think I'm lucky in that I ended up in academia and also having a chance to play and write. But I've always thought a lot about that contingency oriented thing that my therapist said.

MR: That's a good way to put it. I think I'm that way as well, like opportunities come that I hadn't thought about doing that, but I'll give it a try.

ER: Right. Right.

MR: Can you recall the first time, the very first time you wrote a chart, stood in front of the band and counted it off? Do you remember that feeling?

ER: Yes I do. Ray Wright was nice enough to not only program a piece of mine with the Eastman Jazz Ensemble but ask me to conduct it, which was mind-boggling to me. Unfortunately I had done — you know I think — I can't remember if that was before or after my student teaching but I had never ever stood in front of a group like that and yeah, I distinctly remember it.

MR: Were you happy with the way it came out in comparison to what was in your head?

ER: Yeah. I think, you know young writers and I actually still find to this day, you know there's certain things that you just thought were, you know ensembally, going to sound like a certain texture and it comes out a little bit differently. But I was able to — I think probably because I was a pianist and partly because I was a music ed major and really kind of understood the instruments maybe better than someone who wasn't a music ed major, I usually wasn't too shocked. I think it was more sometimes I maybe didn't think about how hard something might be to play on the instrument and how it might not sound as easy and clean as I thought it would or things like that. But yeah, there's usually surprises but you know a lot of times they're pleasant surprises.

MR: Someone said that. "Jazz is the sound of surprise."

ER: That's a nice — yeah, that's a nice quote.

MR: Yeah. One of the early critics — I can't think of his name. I re-read my interview with Bill Dobbins, who I know that you know.

ER: Yeah I do, sure.

MR: And he said something about jazz myths. And he said, "In relation to jazz education one of the things that I deal with, even with jazz majors let alone with people who are not musicians, is they still want to believe this myth that certain people are just anointed from above, or that if you ingest the right substance that stuff is going to rub off."

ER: Yeah, yeah, that pretty much hits the nail on the head. No there's the old adage about perspiration, and you know inspiration and all that. But yeah I mean you're lucky if you have a good ear, you're lucky if you grew up in a musical household, and you know have had access to lessons or whatever, or albums. But you know at the end of the day if you're not putting the time into the practice room and going out to clubs and all the rest of it, I don't see that that's going to get you all that far.

MR: Can you remember your worst gig ever?

ER: It's a toss up between the one in the bowling alley or the one in the used car rental parking lot. And I think it was the same band leader on both. But you know — rest in peace — but yeah I think I did a lot of club dates when I was at Eastman, as did my peers. And we had a band leader who would send us out to all these strange places, and he would turn up for a little bit of each gig and then vanish to go on to the next one. And I just remember that the people who had hired him were always angry because they'd come up and say, "Where has he gone?" And I won't even mention his name, but — and we'd say, "Oh gosh yeah, I don't know." But yeah one of those gigs he booked some kind of party where — playing electric piano in a bowling alley, and the other one was outdoors in a used car dealership outside in the parking lot.

MR: That's called paying dues.

ER: Yes. Yes it is.

MR: I just got this image, you know you portrayed the sound of two tennis players briefly, I wonder if you could do that with a bowling alley.

ER: Okay, you've got me thinking. That's going to — that's a challenge I may not be able to turn down. Pins going down. That's going to be interesting.

MR: Pins going down, ten of them now.

ER: Yeah.

MR: Wow. Who were the influences piano-wise? You mentioned Marian McPartland.

ER: Marian was just, as she was for so many people, especially women players I think, you know a mentor, she always looked out after me and gave me opportunities. I heard her playing a little bit. My parents had some LPs with her on it when I was growing up. But

what really turned the corner for me I think was when I got to study with John Mehegan, who lived one or two towns away from me in Connecticut. And I walked in there and suddenly there's a lot of music for which I had no real true cultural reference. I mean he was playing Bud Powell and Thelonious Monk and Horace Silver for me and those were players I just had not been exposed to, and, but he was also playing Bill Evans and Herbie. And the first player I think to resonate with me the most closely was Bill Evans, and he still remains a touchstone for me. But starting to try to understand some of those players and you know I mean and I think about this a lot and talk about it a lot too, but I grew up in a completely white environment. My high school, you know I had one black friend all throughout high school. College wasn't that much better. Eastman at the time was not very diverse. And so to try to really start understanding more about the roots of the music, to try to figure out what would turn a corner for me in terms of incorporating the swing feel and being able to express myself that was has been a lifelong, you know, challenge. I think I'm getting closer to it the more, you know players I transcribe and the more time I spend in the black churches in Detroit and things like that. But yeah so I mean I'd have to say the first person who I kind of thought oh I think I understand what's happening there melodically and harmonically and maybe that's something I can start, you know, trying to approach, would be Bill. You know I love Keith Jarrett and Herbie's music has always just appealed to me on so many different levels. And now I can say honestly that I just completely revere Barry Harris and Tommy Flanagan and Cedar Walton and all the great Detroit players, you know, not Cedar necessarily a Detroit player, but Hank of course, Hank Jones and so, but yeah, Bill was probably the first big influence. And then like I said Marian just — I think I got influence from her as much from transcribing all her solo piano recordings as anything. And then like I said, she was hugely helpful to me. She gave me a key to her upper east side apartment when I was in New York I could go in and stay there. She had me write pieces for her, arrangements for some of her trio arrangements that she was going to be doing with an orchestra, a small chamber orchestra in Boston. Yeah. Just opened up the door. Lots of opportunities. And had me on "Piano Jazz" twice. I mean how lucky is that?

MR: About what years was — this occurred?

ER: "Piano Jazz" was 1990 and the other one might have been 1996. I've got to check my years on that but I definitely know 1990 was one of them. And so I had only been college teaching for about five years at that point. But I just remembered being pretty terrified going down to New York and finding the studio and there were the two pianos side by side and she didn't like to do extra takes if she didn't have to so off we went.

MR: I was teaching in a high school near here in about 1975 and she came for a concert. And I was like stunned because I knew who she was and at the level she played, and nobody in

the school really knew who Marian McPartland was. But I remember thinking well even at this level she needs to make a living and she's being part of this program that will send you to schools and so forth and it was a good lesson to learn.

ER: Um hum. Yeah, she was a great ambassador for the music, we had her out to Connecticut, had her out here to Michigan, and she had an ongoing relationship with a high school out in Long Island and I used to go out and kind of oversee those residencies with the band director and she would just come in and work with any level of student that was there, she would play with them and she was just so gracious. One favorite McPartland story of mine is that she came out to the University of Michigan and the dean and development director said, "Hey we need to turn this into a donor possibility and have some of our more affluent donors who would like to, have dinner with her." And so I set the whole thing up and of course the development people helped me out a lot. But you know it was one of the nicest restaurants in Ann Arbor and there was special menus made up for the occasion honoring her. And nobody — I guess — thought to proofread those lovely menus. And so it said, "The University of Michigan honors Marian McPratland" P-R-A-T-L-A-N-D. And I showed it to her with — very embarrassed. And her comment, in typical Marian fashion was, "Well at least they didn't say 'Marian McFartland.'" I said oh thank you, good. I feel like I'm off the hook.

MR: Oh. Did she ever tell you about the time her uncle came from England, you know, an aristocratic type person and came to where she was playing. And he goes, "Margaret! Do your parents know what you're doing here?" It was so funny the way she said it, you know like what are you doing in a bar.

ER: Well I mean of course the thing that's legendary, one of the many things that's legendary about Marian was just the mouth on her that you would never guess in a million years sitting on the Piano Jazz show, but you get her backstage with her band or in the green room or whatever, and oh my God, I mean she had a mouth on her and she was not afraid to let all kinds of "blue" things fly.

MR: Nice.

ER: So I didn't get to witness too much of that but the guys I talked with who played with her on a regular basis sure have stories.

MR: This is a rather vague question but do you think the political environment that's going on now will have an effect on your programs at Michigan and coupled with that question is do you think that sometimes we are in a university bubble, that we're not really in touch with what's going on outside the bubble?

ER: Well again, amazing questions. One of the things I've noticed at least about Michigan is that there may be a bit of a bubble but Ann Arbor itself is a vibrant town politically. And our students, I think in the school music — or the entire university — I think they're very

socially aware. I mean I really should only speak for the students that I work with in the jazz program. But they're very concerned, you know, about what's going on and I think we're trying to encourage them rather than to just, you know many of them of course are fairly liberal. Instead of falling into a pit of despair, to use their music and whatever volunteer activities, community activism they can do, you know to try and make a difference and then to see what they can do to enact some positive change. But I see a lot of concern for climate issues, you know, all across the board there's concern. But I don't worry so much about the jazz department per se or the school of music per se, things like that. I mean we're well established. I don't think we're making a case for ourselves politically one way or the other, I mean we're trying to stay neutral and just help support our students. Of course the fact that jazz has always been sort of a — I don't want to say leftist but a hotbed for people who have things to say and have strong opinions I think is great but I don't think we're going to suffer. I'll see, but I don't think we're going to suffer because of it. I do think obviously if you read the *New York Times* you know that there's a huge article on the DEI programs here and while I think a lot of that reporting was unfair, you know I think there's going to be some pushback and not just at Michigan, I think you know across the country, just as the pendulum swings back and forth. But I'm not too worried about our program per se.

MR: I see that, I forget where it was mentioned that you're a — here it says right here — accomplished outdoors woman, mountain climber and trail hiker.

ER: Yeah.

MR: So I'm picturing you, can you remove music — something you're working on — when you go out and hike? Or is it always like intruding on your thoughts.

ER: Well I mean my two passions are mountain climbing and actually trail running. And so when I'm running on the trails there may be a musical backdrop but when you're trail running you have to be super focused on where you're putting your feet and so yeah, not so much — when I'm hiking definitely, yeah. I mean there's always something going on. And even with the trail running I mean I know I'm sort of problem solving, you know musical things when I'm running. But yeah, the focus with the trail running again, you know, as I've got some cuts and scrapes all over my body from falls I've taken. But yeah, not the music is sort of always there just in differing degrees. But what I find from both of those experiences is that when I'm finished there's a sense of perspective that both helps solve musical dilemmas and personal dilemmas, even if I haven't necessarily been thinking about those specific things while I'm out there, but just for me, and I really preach this to my students just being out in nature, period. It's so incredibly important. And moving through nature fast, you know when you're running or slower when you're hiking, just kind of centers me and I find it really centers our students as well. We have a

lot of meditation classes as part of our program as well. And some of it is outdoor walking meditations. I don't teach those but yeah. So there's definite problem solving that goes on, sometimes unconsciously.

MR: Do you like moments of silence in your music? Or maybe not total silence but I'm thinking about layers and room to breathe?

ER: Yeah. I find the fact that my first tendency will be to overwrite, you know as I'm trying in a zeal to get things on the page, and then I try to — and Ray taught us all this — every time I'd sit down at the page, whether it's a tune or whether it's a big band arrangement or whatever, to go back to the very beginning of it and kind of sing it through and that's when you go oh my God, there is no room to breathe. I need silence here or I need phrase extensions here so that it's not bing-bing-bing eight bars, eight bars, eight bars. And that's where I normally, you know it's that process that sort of shows me that yeah it's overwritten or it's too busy. But yeah those spaces are so important in the timing of events and texture changes, whatever it might be.

MR: That's one good thing I found about Finale is you could go back and take stuff out and it's better and sometimes you feel bad, like I haven't written anything for a while for the bass trombone, it's sitting there.

ER: Right.

MR: But okay, that's their contribution.

ER: Is to just sit there.

MR: Silence is a contribution.

ER: Yeah no that's probably important. Yeah I always find I'm rarely adding stuff, it's normally taking them out. And one of the things I find the most is that I write what I think is an intro and then discover it's actually towards the end of the piece it's actually much more involved than it should be for an intro. And I'm always surprised at things like that.

MR: Did the pop music you listened to as a kid have any influence on your writing?

ER: It definitely did, and I'm still perfectly happy to just write a tune and, you know, in a style that may be more folk or folk-jazz influenced or whatever it might be. But yeah, Carole King, Carly Simon, James Taylor, Elton John — you know the first thing I figured out how to play on the piano, a kind of a pop tune, was "Your Song" by Elton John. And I loved the way he played, I loved his melodicism, and there's some — I don't want to say any of that music is simple. I mean it might not be as — you know there might not be as many sharp elevens and flat nines and this and that, but just the beauty of it, the way it was put together. I mean "Both Sides Now" I just did a trio arrangement on that and every — and again the whole focus on the trio arrangement is to leave lots of space and quiet and just to let the tune kind of speak for itself with a few re-harmonizations here

and there. But yeah, no I love that music and it's still is big part I think of who I am as a musician.

MR: Well you have time to think about what you're going to do when you move on from Michigan? Do you have goals?

ER: Yeah. Some of the things I'd really love to do, of course I want to keep playing, I would like to do more playing and really be able to have some multi nights in a row where you can really develop a rapport with your group. So I'd like to be out playing more and I'm hoping this new quartet album, once I finally pick the tracks and get it mixed and all that, may help promote that. I love doing composer residencies where maybe you have a commission or a school decides they want to play a couple of your pieces and they invite you out to just spend a couple of days. That's really fun. You work with the kids and your music, you can hopefully play a little bit and just talk to some arranging students. I really enjoy that. So yeah I think it's going to be, you know I'm hoping maybe to crank up the amount of commissions. I'm not sure women writers are getting quite as many commissions as the guys, just putting that out there. But although there's some really positive steps, Brava Music Publishing, which is a company that's given over completely to women writers and arrangers, composers/arrangers, which is great. So yeah, and looking for chances to travel, to do some clinics and residencies that will allow me to maybe follow the residency up with some trail running or hiking or something like that. So, and then I want to find some ways to use my music to you know help support some important causes and I haven't quite decided how that's going to take shape but I'm hoping something will occur to me.

MR: I bet it will. Gabe Condon says hello.

ER: Oh please give him my best. We miss him. I can't wait to hear how things are going for him and to catch up with him, and I'm just so happy he landed there.

MR: Yeah. It's a nice feeling that you have a positive influence on people and help them land a gig so to speak.

ER: It is. It's yeah, nothing feels better than to see people who worked with you out doing the things they want to do and hopefully doing them well and yeah, it's very rewarding and it also makes you appreciate all the people who did things for you and helped you get to do what you want to do. So yeah, please give him my best.

MR: I will. Well this has been a really enjoyable conversation, Ellen, and I wish you the best in your next recordings and your compositions.

ER: Thank you. And thanks for, you know, the background. I can tell the work you put in just with some research and the questions were so interesting and so great, you know, things I really love to talk about. So I appreciate that very much.

MR: Excellent. Well I'll pause this and then we'll say our good-byes. Thanks again.

666 ER: You're welcome. Thank you.